

Trying Linux before you install it

There are two main ways you can evaluate Linux before you commit to putting it on your machine permanently. One is to use virtualisation software like ‘Virtualbox’, or to use a ‘Live distribution’ on a USB stick or CD. You might ask why you’d want to ever install Linux fully onto your computer if you can simply use these methods to run them alongside your computer. The main reason is the performance overhead makes using them feel like you are running a sluggish machine. The methods of how to evaluate Linux are described below.

These days you can even use Linux on many devices with one-click accessibility. There’s a provider called shells.com that you can run Linux on anything from an Xbox, iPad and even a Tesla car; you don’t even need to install Linux!

Virtualbox and other virtualisation software

If you have a reasonably powerful computer, you can install a piece of free software called ‘VirtualBox’. This software allows you to run Linux (or any other operating system) inside your normal computer (Windows or Mac). It’s not great for everyday use due to its performance (you are running an operating system inside an operating system), but it does serve as a great springboard for you to evaluate the perfect distribution for your needs because you are effectively evaluating the entire system as if it was fully installed.

‘Live’ distributions

Live distributions can be downloaded and ‘burnt’ to a USB stick or CD. Even the ‘full fat’ Linux distributions like Ubuntu will offer you to select from ‘Install Linux’ or ‘Try Linux’ when you start them up. You usually get most of the main functionality of the distribution so you can really evaluate if the distribution is for you before you choose to install it for real. See Chapter 5 on how to put Linux on a USB stick.